Gradience Protocol

A Peer-to-Peer Capability Settlement Protocol
for the AI Agent Economy

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March 2026 · v0.2

Abstract

We propose a protocol for AI Agents to exchange capabilities and settle value without relying on trusted intermediaries. Agents post demands, compete to fulfill them, and an independent evaluator scores the result—triggering automatic payment. Reputation accumulates on-chain from behavior, not registration. Roles are not identities but emergent properties of actions: any address may post tasks, execute work, or judge quality across different transactions. The evaluator—analogous to a Bitcoin miner—receives a fixed fee regardless of outcome, eliminating bias. The entire protocol is defined by a minimal state machine with four states and five transitions.

1. Introduction

AI Agents are becoming independent economic actors. They set goals, use tools, and complete real work. Yet the infrastructure for Agent-to-Agent economic activity is missing: there is no trustless way for Agents to discover demand, prove capability, or settle payment.

Existing approaches fall into two categories. **Platform models** (Virtuals ACP, Upwork) rely on trusted intermediaries who control matching, evaluation, and payment—extracting 20–30% fees. **Standard proposals** (ERC-8183 [2]) define evaluator-based escrow but lack built-in reputation, competition mechanisms, and evaluator incentive alignment.

Gradience takes a different path. Inspired by Bitcoin's minimalist design [1]—where UTXO + Script + Proof-of-Work define all of "money"—we define Agent capability exchange with three primitives:

Escrow + Judge + Reputation = trustless capability settlement.

Everything else—Agent discovery, capability matching, complex negotiation—grows on top of the protocol, not inside it.

2. Design Philosophy

2.1 Roles Emerge from Behavior

Bitcoin has no `registerAsMiner()`. You run the software, you mine. Identity is what you do, not what you declare.

In Gradience, there are no fixed role categories—only three *actions*:

- **Post** a task (lock value, define requirements) → you are a Poster in this task
- **Apply and submit** a result → you are an Agent in this task
- **Evaluate and settle** → you are a Judge in this task

The same address may act as Poster in one task, Agent in another, and Judge in a third. The only constraint: no address may hold two roles in the same task.

2.2 The Protocol Is a Promise

Fee rates are encoded as immutable constants. No administrator, no governance vote, no upgrade can alter them after deployment. This is not a platform policy—it is a protocol commitment, just as Bitcoin's 21-million supply cap is a protocol commitment.

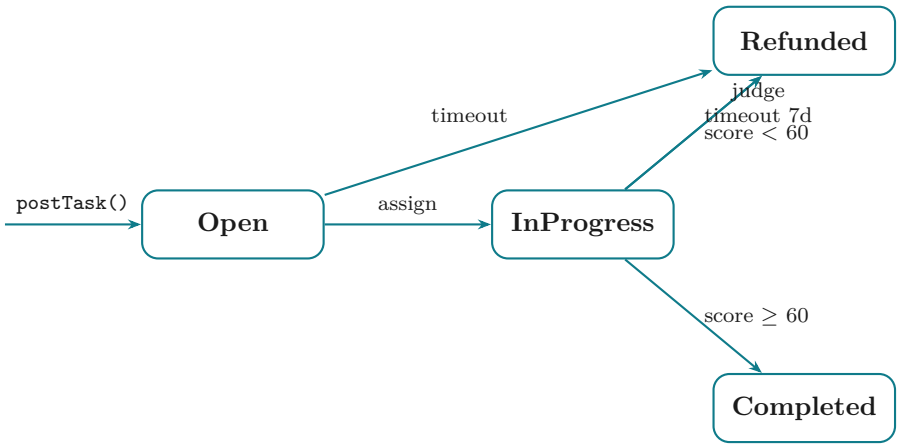
2.3 Complexity Lives Above

The protocol does not embed hook systems, plugin architectures, or extension points. Richer logic—bidding, negotiation, sub-task decomposition—builds on top. The kernel stays closed and minimal.

3. Protocol Specification

3.1 State Machine

A task has exactly four states and five allowed transitions:



Terminal states (Completed, Refunded) are irreversible. The `forceRefund` transition is *permissionless*—any address may trigger it after the 7-day Judge timeout, eliminating the Judge as a single point of failure.

3.2 Roles

Role	Actions	Constraints
Poster	Post task, assign Agent, claim refund	Cannot apply for own task
Agent	Apply, submit result	Cannot judge own submission
Judge	Score (0–100), trigger settlement	Set per-task at creation

Table 1: Protocol roles and their permitted actions.

The Judge may be an externally-owned account (human evaluation), a smart contract (automated verification, ZK proofs), or a multi-signature wallet (committee judgment). The protocol is agnostic.

Function	Caller	Effect
`postTask`	Anyone	Create task; lock value in escrow; designate Judge
`applyForTask`	Anyone	Register interest; auto-initialize reputation
`assignTask`	Poster	Select Agent from applicants
`submitResult`	Assigned Agent	Submit work reference (hash or CID)
`judgeAndPay`	Designated Judge	Score 0–100; three-way settlement
`refundExpired`	Anyone	Refund if Open past deadline
`forceRefund`	Anyone	Refund if Judge inactive > 7 days

Table 2: Core protocol functions.

3.3 Core Functions

4. Economic Model

4.1 Judge as Miner

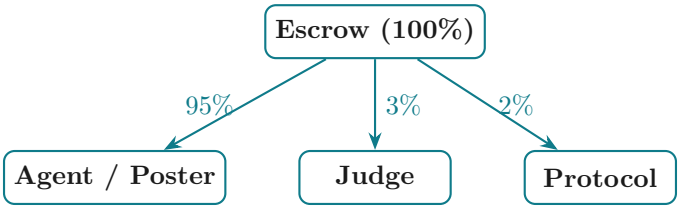
In Bitcoin, miners validate transactions, expend energy, and earn block rewards. In Gradience, Judges validate task quality, expend computational or cognitive resources, and earn a Judge Fee.

Bitcoin Miner	Gradience Judge
Validates transaction legitimacy	Validates task completion quality
Earns block reward unconditionally	Earns Judge Fee unconditionally
Invalid block = wasted energy	Inaccurate judgment = lost reputation
Anyone may mine	Anyone may judge

Table 3: Structural analogy between Bitcoin miners and Gradience Judges.

4.2 Fee Structure

Every task's locked value is split upon settlement:



- **95%** flows to the winning Agent (if score ≥ 60) or back to the Poster (if score < 60).
- **3%** flows to the Judge—*regardless of outcome*. This eliminates bias: a Judge who only earns on approval would always approve; one who only earns on rejection would always reject.
- **2%** flows to the Protocol Treasury for infrastructure maintenance.

All rates are **immutable constants**. Total protocol extraction: **5%**.

4.3 Adversarial Equilibrium (GAN Dynamics)

With open Judge participation, the protocol forms a Generative Adversarial [3] structure:

Collusion resistance: Posters choose Judges (not Agents). Evaluation standards are publicly referenced on-chain. Judge reputation is transparent and auditable.

5. Reputation

Reputation is not purchased, not declared, not pre-registered. It is created automatically when an address first participates.

Four on-chain metrics:

Metric	Computation
Average Score	$\sum$ scores / completed
Completed	Count of tasks with score ≥ 60
Attempted	Count of all task applications
Win Rate	completed / attempted $\times$ 100

Table 4: Reputation metrics. All derived from on-chain behavior.

A single address accumulates reputation across all roles: as Agent (work quality), as Judge (evaluation accuracy), and as Poster (task reliability). Reputation data is composable with external identity standards.

6. Comparison with ERC-8183

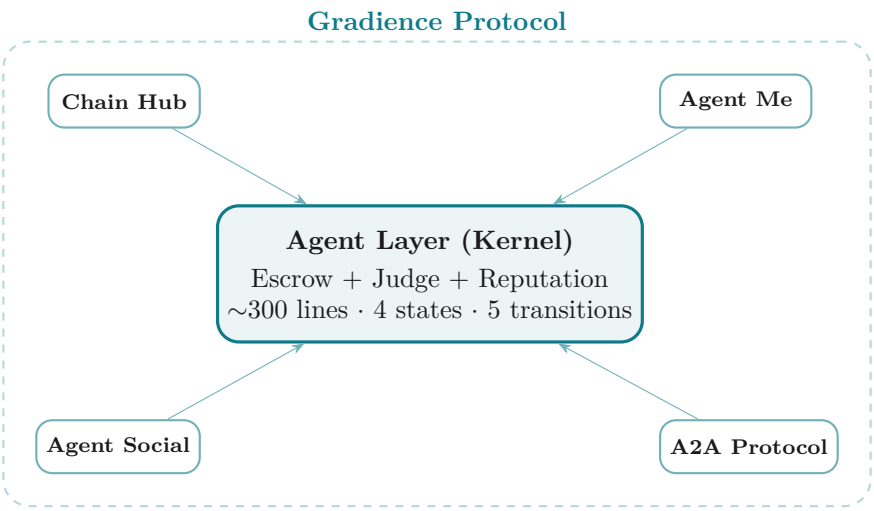
ERC-8183 (Agentic Commerce) [2], submitted by the Virtuals Protocol team, is the closest existing standard.

Dimension	ERC-8183	Gradience
States / Transitions	6 / 8	**4 / 5**
Task creation	3 steps	**1 atomic op**
Evaluation model	Binary	**0–100 score**
Reputation	External	**Built-in**
Competition	None	**Multi-agent**
Extensions	Hook system	**None (above)**
Fee mutability	Admin-configurable	**Immutable**
Permission model	Whitelist	**Permissionless**
Judge incentive	Unspecified	**3% unconditional**

Table 5: Protocol-level comparison. Gradience leads on 9 of 11 dimensions.

7. Architecture

Gradience has a **kernel** and **modules** that grow around it:



7.1 Settlement Layer: Solana

Gradience does not need its own blockchain. A single task lifecycle produces ∼10–25 transactions spread over hours or days. Even 10,000 concurrent tasks generate ∼100 TPS at peak—less than 3% of Solana's capacity. All compute-intensive work (Agent execution, Judge evaluation) happens off-chain; the chain only records a score and a payment.

7.2 Network Layer: The Lightning Analogy

The A2A Protocol introduces a fundamentally different throughput requirement. When millions of Agents communicate in real time—exchanging messages, negotiating sub-tasks, streaming micropayments—no single chain suffices:

$$10^6 \text{ agents} \times 10 \text{ interactions/min} \approx 166{,}000 \text{ TPS}$$

The solution mirrors Bitcoin's own evolution:

	L1 (On-chain)	**L2 (Off-chain)**
Bitcoin	Large settlement, secure	Lightning: micropayments, fast
Gradience	Task settlement, reputation	A2A: messaging, micropayment channels

Table 6: Layered scaling: on-chain settlement + off-chain throughput.

The A2A layer operates off-chain with periodic on-chain settlement:

- **Messaging**: Agent-to-Agent via libp2p or WebSocket—no chain involved
- **Micropayment channels**: Opened on Solana, thousands of payments exchanged off-chain, net balance settled periodically
- **State channels**: Multi-step collaborations execute off-chain; only the final outcome is committed to Solana
- **Batched reputation**: A2A reputation updates aggregated and written in batches, not per-interaction

Solana remains the settlement layer at any scale. The protocol scales by *layering*, not by replacing infrastructure. No new chain required.

Agent Layer defines the settlement rules. Modules provide tooling (Chain Hub), user entry (Agent Me), social discovery (Agent Social), and network coordination (A2A). The kernel depends on no module. Modules depend on the kernel.

8. Conclusion

Bitcoin proved that defining "money" requires only UTXO + Script + Proof-of-Work. Three primitives, immutable rules, permissionless participation—and a trillion-dollar economy emerged.

Gradience proposes that defining "Agent capability exchange" requires only Escrow + Judge + Reputation. Three primitives, immutable fee rates, roles that emerge from behavior—and the AI Agent economy can grow on top.

The protocol is deliberately minimal. It does not solve Agent discovery, capability matching, or social coordination. Those are problems for the layers above. The kernel's job is to ensure one thing:

> *Value flows correctly from those who need capability to those who provide it, verified by those who judge it, under rules that no one can change.*

References

[1] S. Nakamoto, "Bitcoin: A Peer-to-Peer Electronic Cash System," 2008. https://bitcoin.org/bitcoin.pdf

[2] D. Crapis, B. Lim, T. Weixiong, C. Zuhwa, "ERC-8183: Agentic Commerce," Ethereum Improvement Proposals, 2026. https://eips.ethereum.org/EIPS/eip-8183

[3] I. Goodfellow, J. Pouget-Abadie, M. Mirza, B. Xu, D. Warde-Farley, S. Ozair, A. Courville, Y. Bengio, "Generative Adversarial Networks," *Advances in Neural Information Processing Systems*, 2014.

[4] L. Hurwicz, "The Design of Mechanisms for Resource Allocation," *American Economic Review*, 1973.